a large group archive.[28] Freed first visited Magnum's New York offices in 1955, when Inge Bondi, the German-born assistant (and later its director), welcomed him to use their facilities. Magnum advanced a transatlantic image interchange between the United States and war-torn Europe that enabled photographers to self-direct shoots on location, gain proximity to their subjects, and place themselves, even if marginally, in scenes with the people they photograph. Before Freed became a full-time member in 1972, Magnum's most acclaimed photographers had already influenced his approaches.

Rather than sticking to one place or one country, Magnum photographers were encouraged to travel among sites, to develop perspective on local matters and insights across cultures, and, when necessary, to return time and again to reassess. They often plotted their own shoots and importantly maintained ownership of their negatives, adding to their authorial position. For Freed, work that grew out of his travels to the Berlin Wall manifested in reflections on division in America and both West and East Germany. Freed attended to these countries, and their sites of border tension or proximity, by thinking through how their respective histories were reflected and made manifest in the present—most clearly through a focus on several overlapping tropes: legacies of war, rituals of mourning, and postwar reconstruction.[29]

Freed's sense of geopolitical location was balanced by another approach he employed in his work: that of mitigating access to his subjects through viewpoints in the "middle-distance." In other words, he imagined the possibility of connection between his subjects and himself while seeking to mark the social boundaries and historical forces straining coexistence. He refused the objective position and detached eye of the documentarian. As Erina Duganne remarks of another white photographer of this era but apropos Freed's subtextual practices: "[He] places his own unmediated access to [his subjects] into question."[30] In a mode of witnessing, and what Duganne deems as "intersubjective exchange," Freed shares space with his subjects in instructive moments of photographic encounter. He makes that fact known by referencing his presence in many of his images through shadows, reflections in glass, and blurred figures in the immediate foreground. He accomplishes a middle distance by balancing his own visual perspective with that of his subjects by approximating, acknowledging, and/or honoring their fields of vision by denying himself and later viewers access to what they singularly experience and see. The dynamic plays out